swings away late, at first provoking the batter to whip it towards midwicket before straightening dramatically and leaving them squared up, the ball somehow finding the outside edge. I bowled it to Brendon McCullum in 2008, shattering his stumps. Strange how things end up. Ben Stokes comes up to me to from mid-off. I nod. He nods back. As I walk back to the start of my mark, I analyse the last ball. It's all the same questions I've always asked myself. Did it land where I wanted it to? Did it do anything in the air or off the pitch? What did Da Silva do? Did he play at a ball he didn't need to? Do I need to bowl the same ball again or do I need to do something different? Do I need to change the field? It all moves through my mind in 20 seconds; a quick-fire checklist of internal questions. Then I'm at the top of my mark again. Waiting. I've decided. I'm going to bowl that perfect delivery, the one that I throw almost down the leg side and then it shapes – I got the other two ticked off yesterday, so this one would complete the package.

I turn to receive the ball. There is a song in my head as it travels towards me. It's a mantra that briefly appears before disappearing again, reminding me the thinking part is done now, reassuring me that I'm relaxed. The ball is in my hand, where it belongs. It is comfortable. It's how I know everything is where it's meant to be, when I feel the ball with the tips of my fingers. The tips are where all the feeling is. I toss the ball twice out of my hand, re-finding the sensation each time as it lands, reminding the body of what it should feel like when the moment matters. Every time it leaves, it's as if it's on an imaginary string, a wire from the palm of my hand to the centre of its gravity, pulling it back to where I control it. I turn it in my hand as it settles. When it finds its resting place at last, the rope of the ball is rubbing against my index finger, where a callus now lives. The callus is the point at the top of my finger which would once blister as the ball brushed past it, causing repeated, quick, sliced, momentary friction. It has worn hardened and tight and resistant to pressure since. It marks time; all 40,000 of the balls I've bowled for England over 20 years have passed the same, tiny spot. When I feel the ball on it, the specific sensation of that small irritation, the familiarity of a feeling that is mine alone, that's when I know. I'm ready. A few overs ago, I've seen a big screen television replay of Lola jumping out of her seat when I've missed Da Silva's outside edge. This one is for her, I think. She'll like this one.